

II

Sarah

The barren wife who laughed at God's promise, then laughed for joy when it came true.

Sarah was Abraham's wife and half-sister, and she shared every step of his journey of faith. She is introduced with one hard line: "But Sarai was barren; she had no child." She left home at sixty-five, was twice taken into a king's household because of her husband's fear, and tried to build a family through Hagar, with painful results. When God said she would bear a son at ninety, she laughed. Yet God kept his word, and Isaac, whose name sounds like "laughter," was born. Scripture remembers her doubts honestly, but names her among the heroes of faith.

At a glance

Name	Sarai, renamed Sarah; KJV margin: "Princess"
Family	Wife and half-sister of Abraham; mother of Isaac
When	Ten years younger than Abraham; traditionally c. 2156–2029 BC
Key places	Ur, Haran, Egypt, Gerar, Hebron (Mamre)
Key people	Abraham, Hagar, Ishmael, Isaac, Abimelech
Lifespan	127 years (Genesis 23:1)
Main passages	Genesis 11:29–23:20
New Testament	Romans 4:19; Hebrews 11:11; 1 Peter 3:6

"Through faith also Sara herself received strength to conceive seed, and was delivered of a child when she was past age, because she judged him faithful who had promised."

Hebrews 11:11, KJV

The life of Sarah

Ages are worked out from Genesis 17:17. Many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC.

In Ur	● Married and barren Sarai marries Abram; she is barren. She leaves Ur with Terah's family and settles in Haran. <i>Genesis 11:29–31</i>
Age 65	● Leaves Haran When God calls Abram, Sarai goes with him into Canaan, leaving home and relatives behind. <i>Genesis 12:4–5</i>
In Egypt	● Taken by Pharaoh Abram has her say she is his sister. She is taken until the LORD sends plagues. <i>Genesis 12:10–20</i>
Age 75	● Gives Hagar to Abram When Hagar conceives and despises her, Sarai treats her harshly, and Hagar runs away. <i>Genesis 16:1–6</i>
Age 89	● Named Sarah; laughs God promises she will be "a mother of nations." At Mamre she overhears and laughs within herself. <i>Genesis 17:15–21; 18:9–15</i>
In Gerar	● Taken again King Abimelech takes her; God warns him in a dream, and he returns her untouched. <i>Genesis 20:1–18</i>
Age 90	● Isaac is born She says, "God hath made me to laugh, so that all that hear will laugh with me." <i>Genesis 21:1–7</i>
Age 127	● Dies at Hebron Abraham weeps for her and buries her in the cave of Machpelah. <i>Genesis 23:1–20</i>

Key activities

In the KJV, Hebrews 11:11 speaks of Sarah's own faith. Some scholars read the Greek as describing Abraham's faith, with Sarah named alongside him. Either way, the verse honors the promise God kept to them both.

-
- 1 Left home by faith.** She went with Abram from Haran into Canaan, sharing his wandering life in tents. *Genesis 12:5; Hebrews 11:9*

 - 2 Went along with a half-truth.** She was Abram's half-sister, and she agreed to hide that she was his wife, first in Egypt and then in Gerar. *Genesis 12:11-15; 20:2, 5, 12-13*

 - 3 Was protected by God.** Twice God struck the royal house that took her, and twice she was given back. *Genesis 12:17; 20:3-7, 18*

 - 4 Tried to build a family her own way.** She said, "It may be that I may obtain children by her," and gave Hagar to Abram. *Genesis 16:1-3*

 - 5 Blamed and afflicted.** When Hagar looked down on her, she said to Abram, "My wrong be upon thee," and dealt hardly with Hagar. *Genesis 16:4-6*

 - 6 Received a new name.** God called her Sarah and promised that kings would come from her. *Genesis 17:15-16*

 - 7 Laughed and denied it.** She laughed at the idea of a child in old age. Then, afraid, she said, "I laughed not." God asked, "Is any thing too hard for the LORD?" *Genesis 18:9-15*

 - 8 Bore Isaac.** She conceived and bore a son at ninety, and her laughter of doubt became laughter of joy. *Genesis 21:1-7*

 - 9 Demanded Hagar's departure.** At Isaac's weaning feast she saw Ishmael mocking and said, "Cast out this bondwoman and her son." God told Abraham to listen to her. *Genesis 21:8-12*

 - 10 Was mourned and buried.** Abraham wept for her and bought the cave of Machpelah as her grave. *Genesis 23:1-2, 19*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Sarah.

Old Testament

Genesis 11:29–23:20	The main account of her life
Genesis 24:67	Rebekah brought into "his mother Sarah's tent"
Genesis 25:10; 49:31	Buried with Abraham at Machpelah
Isaiah 51:2	"Unto Sarah that bare you"

New Testament

Romans 4:19; 9:9	"The deadness of Sara's womb"; the promised son
Galatians 4:21–31	The free woman in Paul's allegory, unnamed
Hebrews 11:11	"Through faith also Sara herself received strength"
1 Peter 3:5–6	A model for wives: "Even as Sara obeyed Abraham"
Echo: Luke 1:36–37	"With God nothing shall be impossible"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Sarah respond when she overheard the promise of a son (Genesis 18:10–15)?
2. *Understand:* Sarah laughed in doubt, yet Hebrews 11:11 praises her faith. How can both be true?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to force an answer instead of waiting on God?
4. *Apply:* "Is any thing too hard for the LORD?" What situation do you need to bring to him this week?